🎨 The Renaissance: Reading

World History · Unit 3 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Italy Summary, Renaissance Art slides and Crash Course video sheet

Name: _____

The Renaissance: A Rebirth of Ideas

The Renaissance (French for 'rebirth') was a period from about 1350 to 1600 when Europeans renewed their interest in the art and learning of ancient Greece and Rome. It began in the city-states of northern Italy, such as Florence, Venice and Milan.

Italy had several advantages. Its cities were wealthy from Mediterranean trade, and rich families like the Medici of Florence became patrons, paying artists and scholars. Roman ruins were all around. Trade with the Muslim world and scholars fleeing Constantinople after 1453 brought ancient Greek texts back to Europe.

Renaissance thinkers were called humanists. They studied history, poetry, philosophy and the classics, and they believed people could achieve great things in this world, not only in the afterlife. The ideal 'Renaissance man' was skilled in many areas, from art and science to music and sports.

Artists used new techniques. Perspective used lines and a vanishing point to make flat paintings look three-dimensional. Fresco was painting on wet plaster. Sfumato blended colors softly so no outlines show. Leonardo da Vinci painted the Mona Lisa and The Last Supper and filled notebooks with inventions. Michelangelo spent four years painting the Sistine Chapel ceiling. Raphael's School of Athens shows Plato and Aristotle surrounded by philosophers.

Around 1450, Johannes Gutenberg developed a printing press with movable type. Books became faster and cheaper to make, more people learned to read, and Renaissance ideas spread across Europe. In his Crash Course video, John Green argues that the Renaissance mostly mattered to rich people and that many ordinary people did not experience it.

Check your reading

1. Give two reasons the Renaissance began in Italy.

2. What did humanists believe?

3. What was John Green's main argument, and do you agree?